DATA BRIEF · 2025

Open Data for Infrastructure

Comparing open infrastructure data availability across West Africa — what exists, what is missing, and what it means for governance.

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Countries compared	Sectors assessed	Has a geoportal

Context

Open data has become a global governance standard. The Open Government Partnership counts 77 member countries. The African Union's Digital Transformation Strategy calls for open data as a pillar of continental integration. Yet when it comes to the most fundamental data — the location, condition and accessibility of public infrastructure — most African countries publish little to nothing.

This brief examines the availability of open infrastructure data in 8 West African countries: Togo, Nigeria, Senegal, Benin, Côte d'Ivoire, Ghana, Burkina Faso and Mali. We assess six sectors: health, education, energy, water, transport and telecom.

Methodology

For each country and sector, we assessed four dimensions:

- **Existence** — Does a georeferenced infrastructure dataset exist at all (in any format, public or not)?
- **Accessibility** — Is the data publicly accessible without special authorisation or payment?
- **Completeness** — Does the dataset cover the entire national territory or only selected regions?
- **Freshness** — When was the data last updated? Is there a mechanism for continuous actualisation?

Sources include national open data portals, government ministry websites, international databases (HDX, OpenStreetMap, WHO, UNESCO), DFI project repositories and our own operational knowledge from working in these countries.

Findings

Country	Health	Education	Energy	Water	Transport	Overall
Togo	●●●●	●●●●	●●●●	●●●●	●●●●	HIGH
Ghana	●●■■	●●■■	●■■■	●■■■	●●■■	MEDIUM
Senegal	●●■■	●●■■	●■■■	●■■■	●■■■	LOW-MED
Nigeria	●●■■	●■■■	●■■■	■■■■	●■■■	LOW
Benin	●■■■	●■■■	■■■■	■■■■	■■■■	LOW
Côte d'Iv.	●■■■	●■■■	■■■■	■■■■	■■■■	LOW
Burkina F.	●■■■	■■■■	■■■■	■■■■	■■■■	VERY LOW
Mali	■■■■	■■■■	■■■■	■■■■	■■■■	VERY LOW

● = one dimension met (exists / accessible / complete / fresh). ●●●● = all four.

Key observations

— **Togo is the only country with a comprehensive, multi-sector, publicly accessible geoportal.** geodata.gouv.tg covers 23 sectors with 1.25M+ georeferenced assets, updated through the PRISE programme. No other country in the region comes close to this level of coverage.

— **Health and education have the most data — but it is fragmented.** WHO, UNESCO and DFIs have funded facility-level datasets in most countries. But these are often project-specific, outdated, incomplete and not integrated into national systems.

— **Energy, water and transport data is almost entirely absent.** These sectors — which represent the bulk of infrastructure investment — have the least open data. Electricity grid maps, water point inventories and road condition datasets are either classified, non-existent or locked in consultant reports.

— **OpenStreetMap fills some gaps but is unreliable for planning.** OSM data is valuable for basemaps but is inconsistent in coverage, attribution and freshness. It cannot replace authoritative national datasets for infrastructure planning.

— **The gap is self-reinforcing.** Countries without foundational data cannot demonstrate the value of data to decision-makers. Without demonstrated value, they cannot justify investment in data collection. The loop persists.

Implications

For **governments**: the Togo model demonstrates that a comprehensive national infrastructure census, connected to a sovereign geoportal, is achievable within a single government mandate. The investment is modest relative to infrastructure budgets and the downstream returns — in planning efficiency, donor coordination and citizen transparency — are significant.

For **DFIs and donors**: funding single-sector, single-project data collection efforts is inherently inefficient. A multi-sector foundational census — conducted once, maintained continuously — serves every subsequent project. Donors should fund infrastructure data *infrastructure*, not data *projects*.

For **the private sector**: the absence of open infrastructure data is both a risk (poor market intelligence, misallocated deployments) and an opportunity (companies that build data capacity gain a durable competitive advantage in underserved markets).

About Mitsio Motu — Data & Tech studio. Paris — Lagos — Lomé. Operator of geodata.gouv.tg (Togo) and jammm.app (West Africa). 25+ projects across 9 countries since 2018.
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